SOCIOCULTURAL FALSE BELIEF #36 · CHURCH CULTURE AND EXPECTATIONS

“Good Christians never struggle.”

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Where it often comes from

Testimonies that jump from “then” to “now,” cheerful greetings, and unspoken rules about “fine” teach us that struggle is a mark against faith. People hide anxiety, doubt, marriage trouble, and sin, so everyone appears to be doing well alone.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture is full of struggling believers. Paul writes, “For all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God,” and “My grace is sufficient for you, for My power is perfected in weakness.” He adds, “when I am weak, then I am strong.” Elijah prayed that he might die, and God sent an angel to say, “Get up and eat.” The psalmist says, “The LORD is near to the brokenhearted.” Struggle is not the opposite of faith. It is often where faith is exercised and grace is found.

> *“But He said to me, ‘My grace is sufficient for you, for My power is perfected in weakness.’ Therefore I will boast all the more gladly in my weaknesses, so that the power of Christ may rest on me. That is why, for the sake of Christ, I delight in weaknesses, in insults, in hardships, in persecutions, in difficulties. For when I am weak, then I am strong”* (2 Corinthians 12:9–10).

Also see

> “For all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God” (Romans 3:23).

> “While he himself traveled on a day’s journey into the wilderness. He sat down under a broom tree and prayed that he might die. ‘I have had enough, LORD,’ he said. ‘Take my life, for I am no better than my fathers.’ Then he lay down under the broom tree and fell asleep. Suddenly an angel touched him and said, ‘Get up and eat.’” (1 Kings 19:4–5).

> “The LORD is near to the brokenhearted; He saves the contrite in spirit” (Psalm 34:18).

> “For we do not have a high priest who is unable to sympathize with our weaknesses, but we have one who was tempted in every way that we are, yet was without sin” (Hebrews 4:15).

Common self-statements

- Everyone else at church has it together.
- If I struggle, my faith is weak.
- I must say I am fine.
- Real Christians do not feel this way.
- I would be judged if they knew.
- I am the only one.

Common logical errors

- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I am either strong in faith or failing.
- Mind reading: Assuming others would judge my struggles.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling ashamed and concluding that I am a bad Christian.
- Fortune telling: Predicting that I would be rejected if I were honest.

Challenging questions

- Where did I learn that Christians should not struggle?
- Which people in Scripture struggled, and how did God treat them?
- What do I think when I see someone else struggling?
- What does it cost me to say “fine” every week?
- Who might be safe to be honest with?
- What does God say to the weary?

Truth summary

> Struggle does not disqualify me. God’s grace meets me in weakness, and I can be honest with safe people. Honesty makes the church stronger.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Weakness
- Hardship
- Church
- Confession
- Suffering

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Divorce

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God’s care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

Praise You in This Storm — Casting Crowns featuring Phil Wickham
Suffering and tears do not establish that God is absent or uncaring.

I Am Not Alone — Kari Jobe
God’s companionship remains through darkness, weakness, and uncertainty.

Blessed Assurance — Larry Ford and Lillie Knauls with Gaither
This classic hymn celebrates belonging to Christ and resting in His salvation.

Each morning ask: “If I truly believed God’s truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?”

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "Good Christians never struggle"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"Good Christians never struggle." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Where did I learn this?
- ☐ Who struggled in Scripture?
- ☐ What do I think of others who struggle?
- ☐ What does "fine" cost me?
- ☐ Who is safe?
- ☐ What does God say to the weary?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ God's grace is sufficient for me.
- ☐ Weakness is where Christ's power rests.
- ☐ Many in Scripture struggled.
- ☐ The Lord is near to the brokenhearted.
- ☐ Jesus sympathizes with my weakness.
- ☐ I can be honest with a safe person.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **2 Corinthians 12:9–10**
  "But He said to me, 'My grace is sufficient for you, for My power is perfected in weakness.' Therefore I will boast all the more gladly in my weaknesses, so that the power of Christ may rest on me. That is why, for the sake of Christ, I delight in weaknesses, in insults, in hardships, in persecutions, in difficulties. For when I am weak, then I am strong."
- ☐ **Psalm 34:18**
  "The LORD is near to the brokenhearted; He saves the contrite in spirit."
- ☐ **Hebrews 4:15**
  "For we do not have a high priest who is unable to sympathize with our weaknesses, but we have one who was tempted in every way that we are, yet was without sin."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ Honest, not hidden: Each week, note one time you were honest about a struggle.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, 2 Corinthians 12:9–10 becomes: "Sarah can write: "God's grace is sufficient for me in my weakness.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Weakness" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- ☐ List biblical strugglers. Write five and what God did.
- ☐ Pick a safe person. Choose someone who shares honestly.
- ☐ Share one struggle. Say it plainly.
- ☐ Memorize 2 Corinthians 12:9. Say it when you feel you must hide.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "Good Christians never struggle": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Honest, not hidden
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Good Christians never struggle.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I have hidden my struggles to look strong. Thank You for meeting me in weakness. Give me courage to be honest with safe people. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.